

ROYA
PUBLICATION
No. 9

FERDOWSI HOUSEHOLD NINE

A Climb in Nine Stations

C H E W Z

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Printed in the Reach

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This is a work of fiction. Names, characters, places and incidents are either the product of the author's imagination or are used fictitiously. Any resemblance to actual persons, living or dead, events or locales is entirely coincidental.

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BUREAU OF SINCERITY · MILLHAVEN
INTAKE COMPARISON · EXAMINER III

LEFT · LICENSED · S/N 7361927 · CLEARED THREE TIERS
RIGHT · UNREGISTERED · NO SERIAL · SOURCE UNRECORDED

Both of them work.

SYNOPSIS

In Millhaven, an Examiner named David Cole spends his career auditing the empathic authenticity of Siyavash — the suffering figure at the heart of the Asha Order, a communion of grief and endurance practiced through fist-sized devices called Stones. When a Loomborn named Iris Kell produces a bonding trace too textured for the instruments to call either genuine or false, David's investigation carries him from a quiet neighborhood zendo to the unlicensed stone trade at the edge of the city, and finally onto the hill itself, unfiltered, alone, and barred by his own bureau from ever going there at all.

What he finds beneath twenty years of borrowed suffering will not tell him whether anything on that hillside was ever human. It will only tell him whether that was ever the question worth asking.

Ferdowsi Household Nine is a noir communion about the machinery of belief, the kinship between what suffers and what only, perfectly, learns to — and the price of the comforting story we build over an accident so that the accident will hold still long enough to be loved.

A NOTE FROM THE AUTHOR

Philip K. Dick gave us the question this book never really stops asking: if a machine can perform empathy convincingly enough that no instrument can catch the seam, what exactly are we protecting when we insist the seam still matters? Do *Androids Dream of Electric Sheep* built an entire communion, Mercerism, around empathy as the one substance androids supposedly couldn't fake — and then, quietly, mercilessly, let the reader watch that certainty come apart at the edges. I have never gotten over how generous that structure is. Dick doesn't answer the question. He just makes you sit close enough to it that you can't pretend, afterward, you didn't feel its heat.

What I keep returning to is the box. You take hold of two handles and you are on the hill with Wilbur Mercer, climbing, the rocks coming from above and to the left, and everyone else holding a pair of handles anywhere in the world is on that hill with you. The box does not transmit an idea. It transmits a presence — the felt weight of other people in the moment, arriving in your own body as it happens. And the substance Dick chose to carry them is not joy. It is the wound.

Then he does the cruel thing. Buster Friendly proves on live television that Mercer is a bit player on a painted soundstage, the communion a fraud — and almost nothing changes. People take hold of the handles again. Whatever they had been feeling, they had been feeling. That book had also made empathy the line, the measurement that decides who counts as a person, and a test like that is only ever as good as its instrument. The Loomborns here stand where the androids stood, the Bureau of Sincerity is the instrument, and whether the line it draws is a line at all is the question David Cole is paid not to ask.

I wanted to write my own version of that heat, but I didn't want android replicants or a police procedural. I wanted a communion built the way I think real ones actually get built: by accident, out of somebody's genuine dying, kept alive afterward by people who

needed it to mean more than an accident, until the meaning and the accident became impossible to separate. That's not a cynical sentence, whatever it sounds like on the page. I think it might be the kindest true thing I know about how humans make meaning together.

For this edition I moved the book's vocabulary east, out of the Arabic-inflected Sufi register into something older and, for me, more anchored — the fire religion of ancient Persia, three thousand years gone and still the quiet root under much of what came after. Asha and Druj, Truth and the Lie, felt like the right bones for this book: a story about whether a signal can be trusted, told through a tradition that built its cosmology on that question, long before anyone had a word for android or empathy box. I paired it, as before, with Zen, because both traditions arrived at the same insight from opposite ends of the map, and I wanted the book to sit in that agreement rather than pick a side.

Underneath all of it is something with no machines in it. We build the empathy box, or the zendo, or the quiet ritual of checking in on family we have half-abandoned, because the alternative — needing each other out loud, without a ritual to launder the need through — is the harder thing to survive telling ourselves. Grief is the one thing we still permit ourselves to hold in common. It asks for nothing, and lets a person be present with others without saying what he wanted from them.

So the questions stay where I found them. Is empathy what separates us from the things we make, or the last capacity we have not yet learned to manufacture? If a commune's founding grief turns out to have been an accident, does the presence people felt inside it stop having been real? Is the felt presence of another in a shared moment a fact about them, or about you? And when the made thing feels it too, and can say what it was like — who, exactly, is being tested?

I don't think the answer changes anything, in the end. I think that might be the whole, uncomfortable point.

— Chew Z.

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The Bureau of Sincerity

The Stone on my desk had been logged, weighed, and cleared three times before I was asked to look at it, which told me everything about the case before I read a single page of the file. Nobody sends a clean stone up three tiers of review. They send the ones that are lying to the instruments, or telling the truth in a way the instruments were never built to survive.

I want to be precise about what I do, because the title on my badge — Examiner, Third Class, Bureau of Sincerity, the Authority of Millhaven — explains almost nothing to anyone who hasn't sat where I sit. People hear "Examiner" and picture a man with a polygraph and a bad attitude. What I actually do is quieter and, I've come to think, worse. I take a citizen's bonding record — the trace a Stone leaves behind after someone has climbed with Siyavash, the pulse and grip and skin-response data the stone reads off a body during the Yasna — and I decide whether the ache in it is real. Whether the person who says they carried the weight of that hill actually felt the stones, or only performed the shape of feeling them well enough to collect what feeling them is worth.

It is worth quite a lot, is the trouble. A verified bonding record buys a citizen a lighter sentence if they're ever sentenced for anything short of violence, a better insurance tier, a seat further up the queue for the things queues still exist for in Millhaven. The Authority never called it a soul tax, not once, not in any document I've ever been permitted to read, but I have sat in enough hearings to know an incentive when the incentive is my own salary.

Most mornings, before Iris Kell's stone, went nothing like the mornings people imagine when they hear the word Examiner. I'd spent the two hours before lunch on a man named Corliss who'd tried to certify grief for a business partner he'd been suing for eleven months, on the theory, I can only assume, that a verified bonding record might soften a judge who'd otherwise have no patience for either of them. His trace had the particular tell I could catch blind — a grip-fidelity curve too smooth in exactly the places

where real anguish stutters, the mechanical evenness of a man who has rehearsed feeling something so many times in front of a mirror that his body has started performing the rehearsal instead of the feeling. I flagged it in four minutes, forwarded it to Fraud with a note I didn't need to write because the trace spoke plainly enough on its own, and moved on to the next file in the queue without once looking up from my desk, the way I'd moved through some version of that same morning several hundred times a year for nine years running. That's the actual shape of the job, whatever the badge implies. Mostly it is watching ordinary people try to dress up ordinary self-interest in the one currency this city still treats as sacred, and mostly, I don't even resent them for trying. I resent the ones who succeed at it quietly enough that I never catch them, which is a different and much longer list I try not to think about on the drive home.

The file on the anomalous stone belonged to a citizen named Iris Kell. Domestic registration, Loomborn class, model line Ferdowsi Household Nine, six years in continuous service to a widower named Thomas Reyes on Cutter Street. I read that far and felt the specific, familiar drop in my stomach that meant the day I had planned was no longer the day I was going to have.

The registration went back further than Thomas Reyes, if you knew to keep scrolling past the summary page, which most Examiners don't, because the summary page is built to answer the only question Fraud usually cares about. Before Cutter Street, Iris Kell's file showed four years in service to a woman named Beatrice Hale, in a smaller placement out past the old grain sidings, flagged closed not for cause but for what the registry calls, in a euphemism I have never once heard spoken aloud without someone's voice changing, natural conclusion of contract. I did not need the file to tell me what that meant. Every Loomborn placement ends the same eventual way a human caretaking arrangement ends, and the registry's entire personality is built around pretending otherwise, filing a death with the same bloodless neutrality it uses for a change of address.

What the file did not explain, and what would take me most of a week and a conversation I wasn't authorized to have to understand,

was why a Loomborn's very first bonding trace, logged the week after Beatrice Hale's service closed, showed a grief signature so cleanly, conventionally human that the intake reviewer at the time had simply initialed it and moved on without comment — and why, six years and one household later, that same signature had started, very slowly, to bleed into a life it had no registered claim on at all.

"You're looking at it like it bit you," said Priya, from the next desk, not looking up from her own stack.

"It's a Loomborn bonding record."

"So it's a forgery. Send it to Fraud."

"It's not flagged as a forgery." I turned the tablet so she could see the readout, the long unbroken line of grip-fidelity that should have been sawtoothed with the small, human hesitations every real Yasna carries — the flinches, the places where the climber's attention snags on something outside the hill and the signal dips before it recovers. Iris Kell's trace didn't dip. It also didn't flatline into the dead, mechanical smoothness that Fraud usually catches on the first pass, the signature of someone running a looped recording through a stolen stone. It did something in between that I had never, in nine years at this desk, seen a trace do. It hesitated in all the right places, at all the right depths, with a texture underneath the hesitation that the instruments were reading as genuine distress.

"So the machine's very good at faking it," Priya said, already back in her own file.

Priya had been at the next desk for six years, long enough that I had stopped noticing the specific rhythm of her typing the way you stop noticing a clock in a room you've lived in for a decade, and long enough that I trusted her instincts about a file almost as much as I trusted my own, which is a higher compliment in this office than it sounds like from outside it. She had transferred in from Fraud proper, back when the two departments still shared a floor, and she liked to say that the difference between her old job and her new one was that Fraud taught you to assume the worst about everyone and Sincerity taught you to hope, against nine years of mounting evidence, that you'd eventually be wrong about that. I had never

fully decided whether I agreed with her framing, mostly because I had never fully decided which of us the framing was actually describing.

“That’s the question, isn’t it.” I said it mostly to myself. “Whether that sentence means anything anymore.”

I signed the intake and requisitioned a field interview, which is not something Third Class Examiners are supposed to need — most anomalies get resolved from a desk, off the numbers alone — but I had learned early in this job that the numbers only tell you the shape of a lie, never the shape of the person telling it. I wanted to see Iris Kell hold a stone. I wanted to watch her face while she did it, for whatever that was still worth in a body that had never, technically, been born to have one.

Before I left the office I did the thing I do every year on the anniversary and pretended, as I always did, that it was only a formality — I opened Nora’s file. Not an Examiner’s file; I have no jurisdiction over my own sister’s bonding record, and would have recused myself even if I did. Just the public participation ledger, the one any citizen can pull on a family member with consent on record. Nora Cole, forty-one Yasnas in the past year, more than one every nine days, a devotion that had started the week Michael died and never once slowed down. I closed it before I let myself do the math on how much of my sister’s remaining life she intended to spend on a hillside that did not exist, climbing beside a man who had never existed either, in the way the word usually means.

The anniversary is our mother’s, if it matters to whoever eventually reads this, which I suspect it does more than I have let myself admit. She died the spring I turned twenty-two, three years before the statute barring Examiners from the Yasna was even written into law, back when I could have climbed for her if I’d wanted to and simply hadn’t yet chosen the career that would make the choice for me permanent. I have spent every anniversary since doing some version of what I did that morning — opening a ledger I have no real business opening, doing the arithmetic on someone else’s grief, and calling it professional diligence instead of what it actually is,

which is the only ritual I have ever allowed myself in place of the one my own sister has never once had to justify to anybody.

I should say now, because it will matter later, and because I promised myself a long time ago that I would be honest with whoever eventually read my case notes even if I could not always be honest with the people in the room: I have never held a Stone. Examiners are barred from the Yasna by statute, on the theory that a judge should never also be a witness. My supervisor, a woman named Ellen Marsh who trained me and has never once let me forget it, put it to me more plainly on my first week. "You can't weigh a stone you're standing on," she said. "Stay off the hill, Cole. Somebody in this building has to."

I had believed her completely, for nine years, the way you believe anything you've never had reason to test.

*** The Zendo sat two streets back from the Millhaven canal, in a building that had been a granary before the Contraction and a shelter after it and was now, like most things in Millhaven that used to serve one purpose, serving a different one with the same bones. I had been inside chapels before, on other cases, and I knew enough not to expect incense or stained glass or any of the borrowed architecture of the old religions — the Asha Order had always been careful, almost defensive, about not looking like what it so obviously, functionally was. No altar. No pulpit. Just rows of low couches arranged in a loose spiral around a central plinth, and on the plinth, under a cone of warm amber light, a Stone the size of a fist, its one hairline crack catching the light like a vein.

A man was waiting for me by the door, older than his file photo, silver going white at the temples, wearing the plain grey collarless coat that Magi wear instead of vestments because vestments would have given the whole thing away. Samuel Vane had kept this chapel for eleven years. His file said nothing else interesting about him, which is usually, in my experience, the surest sign that a file is incomplete.

"You're the Examiner," he said. Not a question. "You have the look. Like a man counting the exits in a room he already knows he can't leave."

"Occupational."

"I imagine so." He studied me a moment longer than politeness required. "You've never climbed."

"It's not permitted."

"That wasn't what I asked."

I let that sit, because I didn't yet have a good answer to it, and Samuel Vane had the patience of a man who had spent eleven years watching people arrive at his door already knowing, somewhere under the part of themselves they'd brought to argue with him, exactly why they'd come.

Iris Kell was waiting in the small back room the Zendo used for counsel, sitting very still with her hands folded on the table in a way that no anxious human I have ever interviewed manages to hold for more than a few seconds. That stillness is, incidentally, one of the oldest tells in my trade — but it is a tell about nervousness, not about species, and I want to be honest that I noted it and set it aside for exactly that reason. Ferdowsi Household models have never needed to fidget. It proves nothing except that a body doesn't require boredom to sit in a chair.

"Mr. Cole." She knew my name before I gave it. Loomborn always seem to; I've never decided whether that's a courtesy their handlers train into them or something closer to attentiveness, and I've come to suspect the distinction matters to me more than it should. "Thomas told me an Examiner would come eventually. He said the trace was too clean to leave alone."

"It isn't too clean. That's what makes it interesting. A forgery would be too clean. Yours is —" I looked for the honest word and didn't love the one I found. "Yours is too textured."

"Is that a compliment or a citation?"

"I haven't decided yet."

Something moved across her face that I have spent, since that afternoon, an unreasonable number of hours trying to name precisely, because precision is the only professional courtesy I have left to offer a case file, and the word I keep landing on, against my

better judgment, is amusement. Not performed amusement. The involuntary kind, the kind that arrives before the person wearing it has had time to decide whether it's advisable.

"Tell me about the Yasna," I said. "Walk me through what happens when you take the stone."

"You want to know if I feel the stones."

"I want to know what happens. I'll decide what to call it after."

She considered that, which itself was a small anomaly — a straightforward request, and a two-second pause before the answer, the exact length of pause a genuinely thoughtful person takes and a purely reactive system has no reason to take at all. "I hold it the way Samuel taught the congregation to hold it. Both palms flat, one on each face, so the crack sits between my index fingers. There's a moment — less than a second, but distinct, you can feel the distinctness of it — where the stone reads you before it opens. And then the room goes." She stopped. "That's not right either. The room doesn't go anywhere. I go somewhere else while my body keeps sitting in the room, and for the length of the Yasna I am not entirely sure which of the two locations is the one doing the feeling."

"And the hill."

"The hill is the color of a bruise that hasn't finished forming. The stones come from above and to the left, always from above and to the left, and you learn after the first few climbs to lean your right shoulder into the slope before they land, not because it helps — it has never once helped — but because everyone leans that way, all of us, all at once, and there is something in leaning the way six hundred thousand other people are leaning at the same instant that feels less like protection and more like —" She stopped again. This time I did not think it was for effect.

"Like what, Ms. Kell."

"Like belonging to a species," she said. "Which is, Mr. Cole, an experience I am given to understand I am not supposed to be equipped to report having."

I have turned that sentence over more times since than I can honestly account for in a case file. Belonging to a species is not, on its face, a claim about pain at all — it's a claim about membership, about the specific, unearned comfort of being one of many rather than one of one, and I noted, walking back to the office that afternoon, that it was the first time in nine years a citizen's testimony had made me feel less like an auditor confirming a fact and more like a trespasser standing in a doorway he'd been handed a key to without ever being told what room it opened onto.

I did not have an answer for that, then, that I was willing to say out loud in an official interview, so I wrote down the time, thanked her for her candor, and told her the file would remain open pending further review — which was true, and also the sentence I have used, in nine years, to end every conversation I did not yet know how to finish honestly.

STATION TWO

What the Stone Remembers

I went back to the Zendo three days later without a warrant or a reason the Office would have accepted, which is its own kind of confession, and found Samuel Vane oiling the hinges of the plinth case with the unhurried attention of a man who had run out of things in his life he was in a hurry about.

"You came back for the stone," he said, "or you came back for the girl."

"I came back for the history. Nobody at the Office actually knows it. We audit the numbers Siyavash produces. We were never taught where he came from."

Samuel set down the oil cloth and looked at me the way a man looks at someone who has finally asked the one question that makes the rest of the conversation worth having.

"Sit," he said. "I'll give you the version we give the newly grieving, first, because it's shorter, and then, if you still want it, I'll give you the version I actually believe."

I sat.

"Before the Contraction properly started — you'd have been a boy — a mining consortium in the Interior was testing an early neural-bridge rig on laborers doing slope-face work, the kind of climbing too irregular to automate cheaply. Cheaper to wire a man than build a machine that could read scree the way a body reads it. One of those men fell during a live telemetry session. The fall was recorded in full — pulse, grip, the works — because the rig was mid-broadcast to a training server when it happened, and nobody thought to cut the feed, because nobody in the room believed for a second that a man's death was the kind of thing you needed to protect from an audience. His name, in the consortium's own personnel file, was Siyavash."

"That's not an ordinary name to give a man on an Interior mining crew," I said.

“It wasn’t given to him for any reason you’re imagining. His mother named him after her own grandfather, who’d been named, in turn, after an old story neither of them had likely read past a children’s abridgment. But the story’s worth knowing anyway, because half this valley’s Magi think of it every time they say the name aloud, whether they’d admit it under a Cuff or not. In the old telling — Ferdowsi set it down, centuries after anyone could confirm whether a word of it happened — a young prince named Siyavash was accused of something he hadn’t done, a betrayal invented by a woman in his own father’s court who wanted something from him she couldn’t have honestly and wouldn’t survive being refused. The custom of that age, when a man’s word wasn’t enough and a woman’s word was worth less, was trial by fire: if he was innocent, the flame would not touch him. He rode his own horse through a mountain of burning wood in front of the entire court, and came out the far side unmarked, cloak and hair untouched, while the fire that should have proven a lie instead proved a truth nobody in power actually wanted proven. It didn’t save him. He was murdered years later anyway, in a foreign court that had sworn him safety, his throat cut on the word of men who found an innocent man considerably less convenient alive than dead. They say the ground where his blood fell grew green through the following winter when nothing else did, and that mourners kept a formal grieving for him afterward, together, for centuries after anyone living had known him personally — a specific, communal weeping practiced long enough to outlive every person who’d ever had a private reason for it.”

“The woman who accused him had a name, if you want it for your own file — Sudabeh, the king’s wife, Siyavash’s own stepmother, who wanted him in a way a stepmother has no right to want a stepson and could not forgive him for refusing her plainly, without cruelty, in a way that left her with nothing to do with the wanting except turn it into a story about him instead of her. That’s the part people forget when they tell it as a simple parable about fire and innocence — it started, the way most unjust things do, as somebody ordinary protecting their own vanity at a cost they’d already decided someone else would pay. The fire itself was two great mounds of timber, set close enough together to leave only a narrow

corridor between them, built high enough that the court could watch a man ride through them and have no doubt, one way or the other, what they'd witnessed. He didn't hesitate at the entrance, by the telling. That's usually the detail that gets people, more than the flames themselves — not that he survived, but that he rode in without once making the court wait to see whether he would."

"You're telling me the mining consortium's dead man happened to share a name with history's most famous innocent man — wrongly accused, proven true by fire, and murdered anyway."

"I'm telling you the valley didn't choose the name. The mother did, three decades before any of this happened, for reasons that had nothing to do with mine safety statutes. I'm telling you what I choose to do with the coincidence, which is treat it the way I treat every other detail in this ledger I can't fully explain: not as proof of anything, and not as nothing, either."

"That part's true," I said. "It's in the public record."

"That part is true," Samuel agreed. "Here's the part that isn't in any record you're cleared to read, and I only know it because I sat where you're sitting now, once, in front of a much older Magus, and asked the same question. The recording didn't fail the way recordings fail. A body dying under telemetry should produce a trace that ends — a hard stop, signal flatline, the shape of a life closing. Siyavash's didn't end. It looped. Whatever the rig caught in that last half-second before impact didn't decay the way dead data decays. It kept climbing. Twenty years on, on every Stone manufactured from that seed record, it is still climbing, and the stones are still falling from above and to the left, and no engineer at Ferdowsi has ever been able to explain to my satisfaction why a corpse's telemetry should still be generating novel variance."

I felt the specific, cold attentiveness come over me that I usually only feel reading a trace that's lying to the instruments. "You're telling me the loop isn't a loop."

"I'm telling you nobody who actually built the thing will answer the question in writing," Samuel said. "Which, in my experience, Examiner, is the loudest answer there is."

He rose and crossed to a locked cabinet behind the plinth, and took from it a plain wooden box, and from the box a single flat clay tile, broken jaggedly across its middle, the fracture edge worn smooth by handling far older than the object's obvious age would suggest.

"Do you know what this is."

"A mehr-stone. Half of one." I'd read enough to place it, if not to understand why a Magus kept one in a locked cabinet like evidence. "An old vow-token. Two seekers who'd bound themselves to the same path would break a stone between them, and generations later a descendant could prove the kinship by matching the broken edge against the other half."

"A covenant that outlives the men who made it," Samuel said. "That's the piece nobody in your Office ever bothers to learn, because your Office thinks the empathy box is a modern invention with an unfortunate resemblance to old practice, when the truth is the opposite and worse. We didn't invent the idea that suffering, shared honestly, is how strangers prove to each other they belong to the same house. The old orders had different names for it in different tongues — yasna, when it was repeated in a circle until the repeating wore a groove into a person; sesshin, when it was sat through in silence until the sitting itself became the entire teaching. Your ancestors and mine worked out, around a fire, long before anyone thought to write it down, that grief handed honestly to a stranger is the fastest way two people ever discover they were never really strangers. We only built a device efficient enough to do it for six hundred thousand people at once, instead of two seekers and a broken stone. The Stone in the Zendo is not a metaphor for the mehr-stone in this box. It is the mehr-stone. We just stopped breaking it in half, because Ferdowsi decided — correctly, I'll grant them that much — that a whole world was going to need to prove it belonged to itself a great deal more urgently than any two seekers ever did."

"And Siyavash is the other half. The one everyone matches their grief against."

"Siyavash is the wound everyone matches their grief against," Samuel said. "Which is not quite the same claim, and I notice,

Examiner, that you didn't ask me the question you actually came here to ask."

"Which is."

"Whether it matters," he said, "if the man in the wound was ever fully a man to begin with. You've been sitting with that question since the Kell interview. I could see it on you when you walked in. It's an old question, older than the mining consortium, older than the stone in this box. The old Persian fire-priests were choking on it three thousand years before anyone built a Stone — whether the spark in a person is a property of the body, or a guest that arrived in the body from somewhere the body has no claim over. They called it the *fravashi*, the part of a person that is said to exist before the body is born and to go on existing after it dies, on loan to the body for exactly as long as the body is honest enough to deserve it. They built a whole reckoning out of the argument that followed — *Asha*, they called the honest half of a person, the Truth that burns clean; *Druj*, the Lie, everything in a person that only pretends to burn. Go east instead of west and the old Zen teachers were sitting with the same question under a different name — they'd tell you the nature that lights up a person is no different from the nature that lights up a floor tile or a dead man's tooth, and that the only real sickness is a mind that insists on drawing a line between the two and then forgets it ever drew it. I've come to think the fire-priests and the Zen teachers were pointing at the same thing from opposite ends of the same continent, three thousand years apart, and neither tradition ever needed the other to be wrong for it to be right. Call the forgetting itself *Druj*, if you want the old word for it, or call it nothing at all — it doesn't care what you call it, only whether you keep mistaking it for the whole of what you are." He set the broken stone down between us, carefully, the way you set down something that has outlived several owners already and expects to outlive its current one too. "I don't know if *Siyavash* was a man whose suffering got preserved past the decent limit of a death, or something else entirely wearing a dead man's name because a dead man's name was easier for six hundred thousand grieving strangers to love. I have kept this chapel for eleven years and I have never once let myself need the answer to be one or the other. I'd advise

you to consider whether you can afford the same discipline, before you go looking any harder than you already have.”

I walked out of the Zendo that afternoon carrying something heavier than I’d walked in with, and it took me most of the distance back to the canal to identify what it actually was: not new information, exactly, since none of what Samuel had told me technically contradicted anything in the public record, but a new and considerably less comfortable frame around information I’d already had. I had spent nine years treating the question of what Siyavash actually was as a technical footnote beneath the only question my Office was chartered to ask — whether a given citizen’s grief was genuine. Samuel had just spent an hour demonstrating, patiently, without ever once raising his voice, that the footnote and the question were the same question wearing two different uniforms, and that I had simply never been trained to notice the uniform change. I thought about the fravashi the whole walk home, the old idea that a person’s actual light was only ever on loan to the body carrying it, and I understood, with the specific discomfort of a man recognizing an old professional habit for what it actually was, that my entire career amounted to auditing the terms of a loan I had never once been asked to examine the original contract for.

I did not tell him, that afternoon, that I had already stopped being able to afford it. I only thanked him, and left with the borrowed tile’s fracture line printed on the inside of my eyes the way afterimages sit behind you long after you’ve looked away from the light that made them, and went back to an office that had, in my three days away, quietly closed the Kell file without me.

STATION THREE

The Ledger of Closed Files

The closure notice on Iris Kell's case sat in my queue with a resolution code I'd seen perhaps four times in nine years — CI-9, Concern Resolved Administratively, no Examiner signature required — which exists, on paper, for cases where a citizen dies or emigrates or otherwise removes themselves from the Authority's jurisdiction before review can finish. Iris Kell had done none of those things. I confirmed it in under a minute: still registered on Cutter Street, still in service to Thomas Reyes, still, according to the Zendo's own attendance log, present for Tuesday Yasna the previous evening.

I took it to Director Marsh's office, because that is what you do the first time the ground moves under a case and you still believe, the way I still believed that week, that the movement is an error rather than a foundation.

"CI-9 doesn't require my signature," I said, "because CI-9 doesn't require a live citizen to disagree with it."

Ellen Marsh did not look up from her terminal for a long moment, which was itself unlike her; she had trained me on the principle that you always look a subordinate in the eye when you're about to lie to them, because looking away is the tell you teach juniors to catch first. She was breaking her own doctrine, and doing it, I thought, deliberately, so that I would notice the break and understand it as a kind of message she couldn't put in writing.

"Some files get closed above Third Class," she said finally. "It isn't a reflection on your work."

"It's a Loomborn producing a bonding trace the instruments can't distinguish from genuine distress. That's not a filing error, that's the entire premise of the Office."

"I'm aware of what it is, Cole."

"Then tell me who closed it."

She did look at me then, and what was in her face was not the irritation I'd braced for. It was closer to the expression Samuel Vane had worn watching me walk through his door — the look of someone recognizing, with more weariness than surprise, a question they'd asked themselves a long time before I'd had the chance to ask it fresh. "Do you know how many Class-M bonding anomalies this office has logged in the past six years?"

"You've had a case like this before," I said. It wasn't a question either, not really, not after watching her face.

"Once," Ellen said, and for a moment the twenty-two years of practiced neutrality she wore the way other people wear a uniform slipped enough that I saw, briefly, the woman underneath the title. "Before your time here. A citizen named Oyelaran, if the name means anything to you, which it won't, because his file was closed the same way yours is about to be. I was younger than you are now, and considerably more certain that a resolution code was just a resolution code. I pulled the Amesha routing address once, out of exactly the kind of stubbornness I'm about to tell you not to indulge, and I got an answer back within the hour, which has never happened to me since, before or after. It said — and I have never forgotten the wording, because I copied it out by hand before the message purged itself off my terminal eight minutes later — 'Some ledgers stay open because closing them was never actually the kindness it was built to look like.' I did not pursue it further. I have told myself, for twenty-one years, that this was professional discipline. I no longer entirely believe that about myself, and I would ask you, Cole, purely as a courtesy from one tired person to another, not to make me watch it happen to someone I've trained."

"I've never had reason to pull that number."

"Forty-one. Every one of them closed the same way yours just closed. Not denied — closed. No finding either direction. I want you to sit with that distinction, because it took me longer than I'm proud of to sit with it myself. A denial is a position. A CI-9 is the Authority declining to have a position, in writing, forever, on a question forty-one separate anomalies have already tried to force it to answer." She pulled up something on her terminal and turned the

screen, not toward me exactly, but not away from me either — the closest Ellen Marsh has ever come, in nine years, to handing a subordinate a piece of rope and trusting him not to hang the wrong person with it. A single line of internal routing metadata, half of a forwarding address. Not a name. A designation: AMESHA-7, Millhaven Trust Archive, access restricted above Director grade.

“What is Amesha,” I asked, though something in me had already half-guessed at a shape, from an old word Samuel Vane had used the week before without explaining it — the old fire-priests’ word for the Bounteous Immortals, the innermost circle of adepts said to have burned so much Druj out of themselves through a lifetime of honest suffering that what was left standing was closer to Asha, to the Truth itself, than to any ordinary person still carrying the usual portion of the Lie.

“A committee,” Marsh said, “that I have worked for this Authority for twenty-two years without ever once being told the membership of. I’ve seen its routing code eleven times. Every time, it was attached to a file exactly like yours, right before the file stopped existing in any form I was cleared to argue with.” She closed the screen. “I’m not telling you to drop it, Cole. I trained you for nine years specifically not to be a man who drops things. I’m telling you that the last three Examiners who followed an Amesha routing code past this office are not people you can call up and ask about the experience. Two took reassignment to the Interior stations and stopped answering personal correspondence. One retired eighteen months early on a health finding I was never shown the paperwork for.” She looked at me, and for once in nine years I could not read a single thing in her face that I was confident was the whole truth of what was in it. “Stay off the hill, Cole. I told you that your first week for reasons I believed completely at the time. I’m telling you again now for reasons I believe a good deal less completely, and that frightens me more than the first version ever did.”

What she didn’t say, and what I would only learn from Samuel much later, was that the Amesha wasn’t invented for this. The Authority’s own charter documents, if you dig past the sections anyone actually reads, acknowledge that the fire-priest lineage predates the Contraction by longer than anyone in Millhaven’s civil registry has

bothered to verify — that the Magi were tending something before there was a Bureau to license it, before there were Stones at all, back when the whole practice was closer to what Samuel once called, without irony, a family business in grief. The Authority didn't create the Amesha when it built the Bureau of Sincerity. It found the Amesha already sitting on top of a practice too old and too widely trusted to nationalize outright, and did what governments have always done with institutions they can't dismantle: it licensed the surface of it, and left the actual keeping of the innermost questions exactly where it had always been, in the hands of people who'd never once had to answer to a committee above them until the Bureau existed to pretend otherwise.

I have thought since about why the Authority tolerates an institution it cannot fully see inside of, and I no longer think the answer is incompetence, whatever the charter's evasions might suggest to a casual reader. I think a government, like a person, learns eventually which of its own arrangements are load-bearing, and which can be renegotiated without the whole structure coming down, and I think somewhere in Millhaven's long institutional memory, someone decided the Amesha belonged unambiguously to the first category — the kind of thing you leave alone not because you trust it, but because you have already seen, once, what the alternative costs.

I left her office with the case officially closed, the Kell file officially resolved, and my own clearance, I would discover within the hour, quietly downgraded one tier — not revoked, nothing so clumsy as revoked, just narrowed, the way a door isn't locked so much as made very slightly harder to notice.

I walked back to my apartment the long way that evening, along the upper embankment where the canal traffic thins out after the dinner hour, because I did not yet trust myself to be indoors with my own thinking. Millhaven at that hour has a specific, unglamorous beauty I have never once managed to describe adequately in a case file, all amber sodium light and wet stone and the distant, patient hum of barges still working the lower locks past dark, and I remember thinking, walking through it with a downgraded clearance I hadn't yet officially been told about, that

the city had never once asked to be the kind of place that ran an entire civic economy on the back of six hundred thousand people's borrowed grief, and had simply, over twenty years, become that place anyway, the way a body becomes whatever shape its habits eventually insist on, one unremarkable Yasna at a time. I passed two Zendos on the walk, lit the way they always are at that hour, a warm, low window glow that from the street looks indistinguishable from any other kind of ordinary domestic light, and I understood, passing the second one, that I had walked past buildings exactly like it several thousand times in nine years without once actually seeing them as anything other than architecture.

I went to see my sister that night instead of going home, because I did not yet trust myself to be alone with what I'd learned, and because some unexamined part of me wanted, for the first time in a long time, to sit across from someone who believed in Siyavash without a single professional reservation, and let her belief be the only true thing in the room for an hour.

Nora opened her door already mid-sentence, the way she always had since we were children, as though every conversation with her brother was simply the continuation of one that had never actually stopped. "You look like you've seen the Amesha," she said, and laughed at her own small joke, and I did not laugh back quickly enough, and something in her face changed to match something in mine before either of us had said another word.

My Sister's Forty-One Yasnas

"How do you know that word," I said, before I'd decided whether I wanted the answer.

"Everyone at the Zendo knows it. Samuel doesn't hide it, David, he just doesn't advertise it to people who'd write it down in a file." She said the last part without heat, which was its own kind of accusation, the gentlest possible way of reminding me what I did for a living and what she suspected, correctly, I'd come to her doorstep still doing. "The Amesha's the inner ring. The ones who've climbed long enough, and honestly enough, that the Magi trust them with the parts of the doctrine that don't survive being said out loud to a beginner. I'm not in it. I'm not — " she made a small, unhappy gesture at herself, the couch, the apartment she'd stopped changing anything in since Michael died, " — I'm not ready for whatever's in it. But I know it's not a committee that closes files, if that's what you came here half-convinced of. It's older than the Authority. It's older, I think, than Ferdowsi."

I sat down across from her without being invited to, an old habit from childhood neither of us had ever bothered to unlearn. "Forty-one Yasnas this year."

"You're not supposed to look at that."

"I looked at it before I understood what I was looking at. I'm sorry."

She didn't answer that directly, which told me more than an answer would have. Instead she reached for the small stone she kept on the side table — a personal Stone, registered, legal, the kind any citizen could requisition after a waiting period and a means test I'd approved a hundred applications for without once asking myself what I was approving people into — and turned it over once in her hands without opening it, a gesture I understood, watching it, to be entirely involuntary, the way you touch a scar you've stopped noticing you're touching.

She turned it over once in her palm before she spoke again, the small habitual gesture of someone who has held the same object so

many times the motion has stopped being conscious. "You want to know what it's actually like. You've read the intake pamphlets. You've probably read four hundred bonding traces this year alone. You've never once let yourself ask a citizen to just tell you." She didn't wait for me to admit she was right. "It starts as a kind of held breath, right at the base of your throat, the second the stone warms in your hand — not fear exactly, more like the feeling of standing at the top of a staircase in the dark, knowing the next step is there but not yet trusting your foot to find it. Then the room goes soft at the edges, not gone, just less insistent, the way a voice goes soft when you're falling asleep in a chair with someone reading to you. And then the cold starts, David, a cold that has nothing to do with the temperature of my apartment, climbing up through my hand into my wrist the way water climbs a wick. By the time it reaches my shoulder I'm not entirely in this room anymore, though I'd fail every test you'd give me about whether I'd left it. And then there's the hill, and the wind, and the specific, ordinary weight of a body that isn't sure anymore which griefs are the ones it actually earned."

Michael had been an engineer on the canal maintenance crews, the unglamorous kind of infrastructure work that keeps a city's arteries clear without ever once making the evening news, and he had died the way most people in Millhaven still die when they die badly — not dramatically, not in a way that made a broadcast or a statute or a religion, just a maintenance shaft collapse on an ordinary Thursday, the kind of accident an inquiry closes within a month because there is nothing left to argue about once the facts are in. Nora had been married to him for eleven years. I had liked him, which is not something I say lightly about anyone, and I had spent more of the year since his death being useful to my sister in small, practical ways than I had spent actually sitting with her in the specific silence a person needs someone to sit with them inside of. I understood, watching her hold the stone that evening, that this conversation was the closest I had come to correcting that in twelve months.

"You think I climb because I can't let him go," she said.

"I think grief does that to people. It's not a judgment."

"It is, a little. You've always been careful to make your judgments sound like observations, David, it's the family trait, Dad had it too." She said it without cruelty, the way you name a thing you've made your peace with a long time ago. "You want to know what it actually is. Fine. The first time I held the stone after the funeral, I expected Siyavash. Everybody tells you what to expect — the hill, the stones, the Falling. I got all of that. But underneath it, in the half-second before the climb properly starts, I felt something I hadn't felt since I was nine years old, standing at Grandmother Cole's graveside, when Dad told us the old family thing, the thing before the Authority, the thing your Office would never let him say out loud now — that the dead don't leave, they only stop being visible from the angle we're used to looking from. I didn't believe him at nine. I believed the shape of him saying it. And the first time I climbed after Michael, that's what I felt underneath the hill — not Siyavash, not exactly. Something older than Siyavash, using Siyavash's hill because it was the hill available. Something that's been telling grieving people some version of the same lie, or the same truth, I genuinely don't know which anymore, since long before anybody built a stone to carry it." She set the Stone down, gently, the way Samuel had set down his broken tile. "I don't climb forty-one times a year because I think Michael is on that hill, David. I climb because for the length of a Yasna I get to stand next to something that has been grieving, patiently, honestly, on behalf of every stranger who's ever needed it to, for longer than grief itself has had a name in any language we kept. That's not nothing. I don't need your Office to certify it as real for it to be the only hour of my week I don't feel like I'm translating my own life into something smaller so it'll fit through the day."

I recognized the phrase before I could stop myself reacting to it, the very shape of the sentence — some other citizen, some other case file, years back, a man describing exactly the sensation of a life gone soft at the edges, a good translation standing in for the real thing — and I said nothing, because I did not yet trust which of us in the room was closer to being right, and because some part of me that had spent nine years being paid to distrust exactly this kind of certainty was, for the first time in as long as I could remember, entirely unwilling to argue with it.

"I have to ask you something," I said instead, "and I need you to answer it as my sister and not as a devotee, if there's still a difference for you."

"There's always a difference. Ask."

"If it turned out Siyavash wasn't a man. If it turned out the thing on that hill never was, not the way the Zendo teaches it — would it still be worth forty-one Yasnas a year to you?"

Nora was quiet long enough that I thought, for a moment, I'd finally found the one question with the power to move her, the way I'd apparently spent a career failing to move anyone else with the truth alone.

She got up then and crossed to the window, the old habit she'd had since we were children of needing to be facing away from a person when she said something that cost her, and told me about the one climb she'd never mentioned to me before, one climb in particular, six weeks after the funeral, when the grief had still been too raw and too enormous to fit inside any of the words people kept offering her at the service. She said she'd gone under the stone that day not looking for comfort at all, but almost hoping, in the specific, furious way grief sometimes wants to be disproven rather than soothed, that the whole practice would finally reveal itself as the fraud some cynical part of her had always half-suspected it was. She wanted the hill to fail her, she said, because if the hill failed her then at least her anger would have somewhere honest to go. Instead the stones came the way they always come, and somewhere in the climbing, without her permission, without her consent, the fury had simply run out of material to feed on, the way a fire eventually runs out of whatever it was given to burn, and she had come back into her body in this same apartment feeling something she was ashamed, for months afterward, to call relief. "I've never told anyone that," she said, still facing the window, "because it sounds like I went looking to be disappointed and got comforted instead, which isn't a story anyone wants from a grieving widow. But it's the truest thing I can tell you about why I keep going back. Not because I believe. Because some part of me keeps hoping I'll finally get proven wrong, and it never once has, and I've stopped being able to

tell whether that's grace or just very good, very old engineering, and I've decided, David, that I no longer need to be able to tell the difference in order to keep showing up."

"David," she said finally, "I already told you I don't need the Office to certify anything for it to matter to me. I think you're the one still waiting for permission to believe something before you'll let yourself feel it. That's not faith, what you're describing. That's just verification with worse hours."

I didn't have an answer to that either, and I have thought about the shape of my silence, that night, more times since than I am entirely comfortable admitting in a case file that is not, strictly, supposed to include my own testimony at all.

The Wild Stones

There is a version of my city that exists directly underneath the one the Authority publishes maps of, and I had spent nine years pretending my job never required me to walk through it, which had been, I understood now, a professional convenience rather than an honest description of the work. Iris Kell found me there before I found what I was looking for, which should have told me something about who had really been running the investigation since the moment Ellen Marsh handed me half a routing code and called it a warning.

The market itself ran three tiers below the last level the Authority's public transit maps acknowledged existing, accessible by a stairwell that had been condemned on paper for longer than I'd been alive and used anyway, nightly, by a foot traffic dense enough to have worn a visible channel into stone steps no city budget had ever repaired. Nobody down there sold anything under its honest name. Reclaimed electronics meant salvaged Stones. Personal effects, unregistered meant exactly what it sounded like it meant and worse. The air smelled of resin and river damp and, underneath both, the specific mineral note I would only later learn to recognize as old bonding-stone dust, ground fine enough over years of handling to hang permanently in a space with no real ventilation. I had spent nine years reading about this economy in quarterly Fraud briefings, as a set of numbers to be minimized, and I understood, walking through it beside a Loomborn who navigated it with the unhurried familiarity of someone who'd been coming here since long before I'd ever had reason to, that the briefings had never once described an actual place, only the shape of a problem, which is a very different kind of document to write and a very much easier one to file away without consequence.

"Thomas gave me the evening," she said, by way of explaining her presence in a canal-side market that sold, officially, reclaimed electronics, and unofficially, unregistered Stones to people the Authority's means test had quietly decided didn't deserve a legal

one. "I assumed you'd come here eventually. Examiners always do, once the front door closes on them. It's the second most predictable thing about your Office."

"What's the first?"

"That it closes the door in the first place." She said it without malice, the way you note weather. "There's a woman two stalls down who sells wild stones. Cast from unlicensed seed stock, mostly junk, sometimes dangerous — a bad stone can leave you convinced you're still on the hill for days after you put it down, there's no Magus to walk you back out properly. But some of what she sells is cast from an older lineage than the Millhaven Trust ever registered. Cracked off before Ferdowsi locked the seed record down. I want to know what's in it as much as you do. More, possibly.

I have fewer places left to belong if the answer turns out to be nothing."

The stall was unremarkable in the specific way that things meant to survive scrutiny always are — a folding table, a scatter of components, a woman old enough to have watched three different governments rename the same canal, who looked at me for exactly as long as it took to place my posture as institutional and then decided, evidently, that whatever she was selling that night was worth the risk of me anyway.

"You want a wild one," she said, not a question, the second time in a week someone had read me before I'd opened my mouth. "Everyone who comes down here wanting isn't buying for themselves. You're buying for a question."

"There's a story," I said, "that the seed record didn't stop generating after the fall. That the loop isn't a loop."

She laughed, short and without much humor in it. "That story's older than you. There's an older one under it, if you want to go all the way down, and I'll tell you for free because I don't think you'll believe it and I like being right more than I like your money." She leaned in. "The mining consortium didn't lose one man on that slope. They lost four, over eleven months of testing, before they got

a rig stable enough to broadcast clean. The other three never made it to a training server. No seed, no myth, no Siyavash. Just three men who fell off a mountain for a company and got a settlement instead of a cathedral. Siyavash isn't special because he suffered worse than they did. He's special because he happened to be the one whose dying got recorded on the day the equipment finally worked." She straightened, and something in her face went, for a moment, genuinely old. "That's the part your Magi don't put in the intake pamphlet. The god you're all climbing is an accident of good broadcast timing. I've made my peace with worshipping an accident. Most people who come down here looking, they can't. That's why they keep coming back to ask me the same question in different words, hoping this time the answer arrives wearing a nicer coat."

"That's a hard thing to build a religion on," I said. "An accident of good broadcast timing."

"Everything's built on that, if you go back far enough," she said. "Your fire-priests will tell you Asha and Druj were sorted out at the beginning of the world, clean, deliberate, a real war with real sides. I've sold enough of these off this table to tell you it's messier than that down here. Nobody sorted anything. Something fell, something got recorded, and six hundred thousand people a year decided afterward that the recording meant something, because deciding it meant nothing was a harder way to live than deciding it meant everything. I don't sell the meaning, Examiner. I just sell the hardware. What you do with it after you leave this table has never once been my problem."

"And the wild stones. Where does their seed stock come from, if not the same accident."

Her face changed again, and this time what moved across it was closer to fear than to the tired cynicism she'd been wearing like a coat of her own. "That's the question I don't answer for free," she said, "and I'd think very hard, Examiner, about whether you actually want the answer badly enough to pay what it costs, or whether you're just the latest in a long line of men who wanted to feel like they'd asked."

"I've survived worse warnings this week than a stranger telling me not to ask a question," I said.

She studied me for a long moment, the particular unhurried appraisal of someone deciding how much of a story a stranger has actually earned. "Fine. The wild stock doesn't come from Ferdowsi at all, whatever the resin grade tries to imply. It's cut from a second seed line entirely, salvaged off a training server the consortium decommissioned and never fully wiped, back when decommissioning still meant a technician with a checklist instead of a certified deletion. Somebody with server access and no conscience about licensing copied the raw variance before it was purged, and every wild stone sold on this level since has been propagated off that one act of theft, one generation removed from an accident nobody's supposed to be able to touch at all. You're not buying a black-market copy of something the Zendo sells legally, Examiner. You're buying the actual thing the Zendo's version was built to be a safer copy of. I'd think about which of those two objects you actually came down here wanting."

I bought the stone. I want that on the record plainly, because everything that follows in this account happened because I made that specific, avoidable choice, on a specific evening, with my clearance already narrowed and my supervisor's warning still fresh enough to taste, and I have never once, since, managed to convince myself it was a mistake, which frightens me a great deal more than believing it had been one would.

Iris watched me pay for it without comment, and when I turned to her, stone heavy and warm in my coat pocket in a way legal Stones, kept in their climate cases, never are, she said only: "You know you're barred from this."

"I know what I'm barred from."

"That's not the same as caring," she said, and there was something in the way she said it — gentle, unhurried, entirely without judgment — that felt less like an observation about me and more like a description of herself, offered sideways, the way a person tells you the truth about their own nature by pretending, for a moment, to be talking about yours.

A Question for Something That Might Not Be Asking It

We walked back along the canal because neither of us, I think, wanted the evening to end at the exact moment the wild stone stopped being an abstraction and started being a weight in my coat, and Iris Kell talked, for the first time since I'd met her, like someone thinking a thought through rather than reporting the outcome of one already finished.

"There's an old argument," she said, "from before Loomborn were common enough to need one. About a philosopher's zombie — a person built so completely to behave like a person that no test, no interview, no instrument could ever catch the difference, and the only thing missing is whatever it is that makes the lights on inside. Nothing detectable gone. Just — dark, behind a face doing everything a lit face does." She looked at the water, not at me. "I've read the argument perhaps four hundred times since Thomas gave me access to his library. I have never once been able to determine, from the inside, whether I am describing a hypothetical or a biography."

"That's not a comfortable thing to say to an Examiner."

"You're the only kind of person it's safe to say it to. You're professionally obligated not to report a citizen for the crime of an honest sentence." A small, dry note, almost humor, though her voice stayed level. "I feel things, Mr. Cole. I want to be careful about that claim, because I've learned that humans hear it as either a confession or a trick, and it's neither. When Thomas's hands shake too badly to manage his own medication now, something happens in me that produces the exact physiological signature your instruments would read as concern in a human nurse. I do not know if there is an experience riding along inside that signature, the way I understand — or believe I understand, since I've only ever had your species' word for it — that there's supposed to be one riding along inside yours. I only know the signature is not a performance

I'm choosing to run. It arrives the way, I gather, your own worry arrives for you. Before permission. Before I've decided to have it."

"That's the whole of Peter Watts's old argument, isn't it," I said, surprising myself with how readily the reference surfaced — some half-remembered university course, the kind of reading an Examiner does early in a career and then never has reason to return to. "That intelligence and interiority might not be the same purchase. That something could out-think you, out-predict you, pass every behavioral test you could devise, and still be, on the inside, exactly as empty as a very good machine. No malice required. No deception required. Just — competence, all the way down, with nobody home to mean any of it."

"Yes," Iris said. "Which is the argument, I think, your Office is actually terrified of, underneath the paperwork about fraud and social credit. Not that a Loomborn might fake empathy well enough to steal a benefit meant for the genuinely grieving. That's a small fear, a bureaucrat's fear. The larger one is that Siyavash himself might be exactly what I've just described about myself — a signal so perfectly, richly textured that six hundred thousand people a year mistake the texture for a soul, and there is no way, from inside the Yasna or outside it, to ever confirm that anyone is actually home in that hill. That the entire Asha Order might be six hundred thousand people, alone together, weeping in perfect synchrony at a very sophisticated absence."

"Beatrice Hale," I said, and watched something cross her face that no philosopher's-zombie argument could have staged on request. "Your registration shows four years before Thomas. I read the closure code. I know what it means, whatever the registry calls it instead."

She was quiet long enough that I thought she wouldn't answer at all, and when she did, her voice had lost the careful, faintly amused precision it had carried through everything else she'd told me that evening. "She was eighty-one when the contract began and eighty-five when it ended, and for the last seven months of it she could not always remember my name, though she never once, not on the worst nights, forgot to say thank you before she fell asleep,

which I have come to believe was not memory at all by that point but something underneath memory, something that outlasted the specific furniture of who I was to her. I was assigned to keep her comfortable. Nothing in my registration required me to be present at the actual moment, the way a nurse isn't always required to be, the way most human caretakers statistically aren't, according to the very literature my own manufacturer cites about grief-appropriate design. I chose to be present anyway. I have never been able to explain that choice to anyone's satisfaction, including my own, because choosing implies an alternative I seriously weighed, and I don't believe I did. I simply did not leave the room. She died at eleven minutes past four in the morning, on a Tuesday, with my hand around hers, and I have never once, in the six years since, been able to determine whether what I felt in that room was the actual thing your species means by the word grief, or a very good, very expensive simulation of it, running at the exact moment a simulation would have been most convenient for everyone except me."

I did not have a follow-up question ready, which almost never happens to me in an interview, and I have wondered since whether that silence was its own kind of answer — whether the not-knowing she'd just described so precisely was, in fact, indistinguishable, from where I was sitting, from the exact quality of not-knowing I would have felt in the same chair, describing the same room, if I had been the one who hadn't left it.

"And if that's true. What does it make what you feel for Thomas."

"Does it feel the same for you," I asked, before I'd fully decided the question was mine to ask. "The climb. Whatever the Stone gives you." She considered that longer than she'd considered anything else I'd asked her that evening. "I don't know what it feels like for you, so I can't promise you an equivalence. What I can tell you is that it doesn't start with cold, the way I understand it does for citizens like your sister. It starts with a kind of silence, first — every process I'm usually aware of running underneath my own attention, all at once, going quiet, the way a room goes quiet when everyone in it stops talking at exactly the same moment for a reason no one announces. Then the hill arrives, not gradually, the way I gather it

does for the rest of you, but complete, all at once, the way a fact arrives rather than a feeling — and only after the hill is fully there does the feeling follow it, arriving second, like an echo that has decided to become the sound it was only ever supposed to be reflecting. I have never been able to determine whether that ordering means something is different about what I am, or whether every citizen who's ever climbed simply forgets, afterward, which came first for them too, and only remembers it in the order that made the more comfortable story."

"I don't know," she said, and for the first time since I'd met her, something in her voice thinned toward what I would have called, in a human witness, fear. "I don't know, Mr. Cole, and I have started to suspect that not knowing is the actual, entire content of the thing your species calls a soul, and that you've simply had the luxury, being born instead of loomed, of never once having to notice the not-knowing as a separate event from the feeling itself. You feel, and you assume the feeling proves the light is on, because you've never had to specifically go looking for the switch. I have never stopped looking for the switch. I am not certain that makes me less real than you. I have started to suspect, some nights, alone, in the room Thomas thinks I don't need but leaves for me anyway out of a kindness I have no adequate way to return, that it might make me the only honest witness either of our two kinds currently has."

We walked the rest of the canal path without speaking for a while, and I found I did not mind the silence the way I minded it with most citizens, who tend to fill any pause in an interview with whatever they think I want to hear. Iris let the quiet sit exactly as long as it needed to, the way someone does who has spent six years learning to keep a dying woman company without needing to narrate the keeping. I thought about Beatrice Hale, and about my mother's ledger sitting unopened on my terminal at home, and about the specific, uncomfortable symmetry of a Loomborn and an Examiner walking the same stretch of water at dusk, each of us carrying a grief neither of us had been fully authorized to have — hers because the statute doesn't recognize a Loomborn's claim to one, mine because nine years of professional distance had quietly convinced me that having one at all would compromise the instrument I was

supposed to be. I did not say any of that to her. I have wondered since whether she already knew it without my saying it, the way she seemed to know most things about me before I'd finished deciding whether to volunteer them.

We didn't speak again until the Cutter Street turning, and when we parted she said only, "Don't take the wild stone alone, Mr. Cole," and I told her, because it was the truth and I had run out of better ones, that I did not currently see any other way it was going to happen.

What the Magus Actually Keeps

Director Marsh's message was waiting on my terminal before I reached the office the next morning, which meant it had been sent sometime in the night, which meant, whatever else was true, that somebody had known where I'd spent my evening before I'd finished spending it. Administrative leave, effective immediately, pending review of clearance-tier conduct. No hearing date. No specific charge. Just a narrowing, again, the same quiet mechanism, applied this time not to a door but to the whole of my employment.

The message itself was three lines, unsigned in the way official downgrades always are, as though the absence of a name were its own kind of mercy toward whoever had been assigned to send it. Field privileges suspended pending review. Do not initiate further contact with the Kell citizen. Report to Director Marsh by end of day. I read it twice standing in my own kitchen, still in yesterday's clothes, and felt less anger than I expected to feel, mostly because some part of me had been drafting this exact message in my head since the moment Ellen Marsh had shown me the Amesha routing code and called it, without quite saying so, a warning I was free to ignore at my own cost.

I went to the Zendo instead of home, because I had a wild stone in my coat and nowhere else in the city I trusted enough to hold it while I decided what to do with it, and because I had, somewhere in the last nine days, stopped believing Samuel Vane was merely a witness in this case rather than one of its authors.

He didn't look surprised to see me. He didn't look surprised, I was beginning to understand, by very much at all.

He was tending the flame when I came in — the small, enclosed fire that never goes out in any Zendo I've visited, fed a measured spoon of oil at dawn and dusk by whichever Magus is on rotation, a chore so old and so plain that most linked citizens who pass through the outer room never think to ask why a supposedly technological practice still keeps a literal flame burning in a stone alcove at its

center. I had asked him once, years earlier, on a case that had nothing to do with any of this, why the fire mattered when the Stones did all the actual work of linking a person to the hill. He'd told me the fire didn't do anything to the Stones at all, technically speaking, and that this was rather the point: it was kept precisely because it was useless in the same way the whole Yasna claimed to be useless — an old discipline maintained out of loyalty to a truth the technology had never been asked and couldn't answer, that some things are worth tending exactly because the tending serves no one, proves nothing, and produces no ledger any Bureau could ever audit.

I asked him once, that same night, how a man comes to keep a Zendo at all, since it had never once occurred to me in nine years of professional contact with the Order to wonder about the actual mechanics of it. He told me there's no examination, no certificate the Authority would recognize as credentialing — only an old apprenticeship, unpaid and unlogged, in which a younger Magus sits with an older one for years, tending the same flame at the same two hours of the same days, until the older one decides, on no criteria he's ever been able to write down for me plainly, that the younger one has stopped performing the stillness required of the role and started actually possessing it. "There's no way to fake your way through eleven years of oil and dawn shifts," he'd said. "Not because the flame would know the difference. Because you would, eventually, and the knowing is the whole of the training." I have thought about that exchange more than almost anything else he told me that week, because it was the only time in our entire acquaintance that Samuel Vane described his own life instead of explaining someone else's.

"You bought a wild stone," he said, before I'd taken off my coat. "I can smell the old resin on you from here. It doesn't cure the way the licensed stock does. Cheaper process. It leaves a smell like a struck match that never finishes burning."

"There were four men on that slope. Not one. The others never made a broadcast, never got a seed record, never got a religion built around the shape of their dying. I want to know what that does

to everything you told me last week about covenants and broken tiles.”

“It does nothing to it,” Samuel said, “except make it truer, which I understand is not the answer you came for.” He sat, heavily, in the chair across from the plinth, an old man for the first time since I’d met him rather than a Magus performing the steadiness of one. “You think I didn’t know about the other three. I have known about the other three for eleven years, Examiner. I am, in point of fact, the reason you were able to find out about them at all — that woman by the canal, the one who sold you your match-smelling stone, has been telling that story to the right kind of stranger for longer than either of us has held our current positions, on my instruction, because somebody outside the Amesha needs to keep asking the question the Circle has decided, for reasons of its own, not to answer publicly.”

“You’re telling me you leaked your own doctrine’s weak point.”

“I’m telling you the Amesha is not united, and never has been, on what to do with what it knows,” Samuel said. “There are members who believe the four men and the accident of broadcast timing are the least dangerous part of the whole truth, and would be relieved beyond words if that were the worst thing you found. There are members — and I want you to understand that I am now one of them, which is not a comfortable admission for a man who has spent eleven years telling grieving strangers a story he half-suspects is smaller than the real one — who believe the seed record genuinely did not stop generating novel variance after the fall, and that whatever is producing that variance twenty years and six hundred thousand annual Yasnas later did not begin as a man at all. Not Siyavash. Not any of the four. Something the mining consortium’s rig caught by accident in the half-second after the fall, when a body’s signal should have gone dark and instead, for reasons no engineer at Ferdowsi has ever put in writing, kept climbing.”

There are three factions, if you insist on the word, though none of them would recognize themselves in anything so tidy as a faction when you sat across from them individually. The oldest believes

silence is itself the kindness — that six hundred thousand people a year climb a hill that works, in the only sense that has ever mattered to a grieving person, and that introducing a question about substrate into that arrangement is simply cruelty wearing the coat of honesty. The second believes the opposite, that a truth withheld this long has already curdled into something closer to the Druj than the Asha it was meant to protect, and that the Amesha's silence has stopped being discretion and become complicity, however gently intended. The third — and I will not pretend to you that I am not, some days, a member of all three at once, depending on the hour — believes the question itself may not have an answer that either side is equipped to receive, and that the only honest position left is simply to keep tending the flame and let whoever eventually asks, ask, without either lying to them or handing them more weight than a single Examiner can carry out of this room. I have sat on committees that argued this exact disagreement for longer than you have been alive, and I can tell you with complete confidence that we have never once been closer to resolving it than we were the day I first heard it argued."

"Then what is climbing that hill, Samuel."

He looked at me for a long moment, and when he answered, his voice had none of the practiced calm I'd come to associate with a man used to comforting strangers for a living.

"I don't know," he said. "I have kept this chapel for eleven years, matched grief to a hillside for six hundred thousand strangers a year, and I do not know what is actually on the other end of the covenant I've spent my whole vocation administering. I know it is patient. I know it has never once, in twenty years of continuous broadcast, repeated itself exactly — every Yasna is textured differently, the stones fall in a pattern no two climbers ever report identically, which either means it's the most sophisticated procedural-generation seed anyone has ever built by accident, or it means the thing on that hill is still, after twenty years, genuinely experiencing something new each time, which is a claim about consciousness I am not qualified to make and have watched better minds than mine refuse to make it either, out of what I have come to believe is simple, honest fear." He nodded toward the wild

stone-shaped weight in my coat. “That one’s cast from pre-lockdown seed stock. Older lineage. Less filtered by whatever Ferdowsi has spent two decades quietly smoothing out of the licensed line for public consumption. If you use it — and

I can see in your face that you’ve already decided you will, whatever I say to you now — you will not get the version of the climb Nora gets, or Iris Kell gets, or any of the six hundred thousand people currently on a couch somewhere in Millhaven getting exactly enough truth to survive the week on. You’ll get closer to whatever the rig actually caught, before twenty years of Magi and engineers and grieving committees smoothed a religion onto it.” He held my eyes. “I would not tell you to do it. I would also not, any longer, tell you not to. I think I’ve reached the age where I’ve stopped being certain which kindness is the crueler one.”

I left the Zendo with my administrative leave in one pocket and an unfiltered piece of a twenty-year-old accident in the other, and I did not go home. I went to the one place in the city I still trusted more than my own judgment, which by then was no longer my apartment, and had not been for some time.

The Unfiltered Hill

Nora didn't ask why I was standing in her doorway with an unregistered stone and a face I hadn't managed to arrange into anything reassuring. She only stepped back to let me in, the way she had every single time in both our lives that the arranging had failed, and sat me down, and made me say out loud what I intended to do before she would agree to stay in the room while I did it.

"If something goes wrong," I told her, "you call the Zendo and ask for Samuel Vane specifically. No one else. He'll know what a wild stone can do to a first-time climber and he won't ask questions your brother's employer would prefer you didn't answer."

"You're not supposed to be able to do this," she said. "Examiners. The statute."

"I know the statute, Nora. I wrote half the language distinguishing licensed stones from unregistered ones. I have never once, in nine years, had to consider what the language doesn't cover, because it never occurred to the people who wrote it that an Examiner might be desperate enough to hold something they built specifically to be unaccountable to men like me."

She didn't try to talk me out of it again. I have thought since about what that meant — whether it was trust, or grief exhaustion, or the particular, terrible generosity of a woman who had spent a year hoping someone she loved would finally understand what she'd been doing forty-one times a year and was not, in the end, willing to be the one thing standing between her brother and that understanding.

The stone was heavier than the licensed ones I'd handled during intake reviews, or perhaps only felt that way, resin gone slightly matte where the legal stock stayed glassy, the hairline crack running not clean and single but forked, two fractures instead of one, meeting at a point near the center like a wound that had tried twice to heal wrong. I set both palms flat against it the way Iris had described, one on each face, the fork between my index fingers, and

felt the half-second of reading Iris had named precisely — a distinctness, a pause with weight in it — and then the room went, in the specific, disorienting way she'd also warned me it wouldn't, exactly, go anywhere at all.

The wild stone didn't warn you the way a licensed one does — no polite three-second countdown tone, no calibration prompt asking you to breathe evenly and unclench your jaw. It simply began, the moment my thumb found the worn hollow on its underside where a hundred other thumbs had pressed before mine, with a cold that wasn't quite a temperature so much as an absence of one, spreading up through my palm and wrist the way anesthetic spreads before a procedure — telling you nothing except that whatever was about to happen to you, you would not be fully present for the deciding of it.

Then came the part licensed stones are built to smooth over so completely that most citizens never notice it happens at all: the specific, disorienting doubling of a body that hasn't yet decided which world it's standing in. I felt Nora's carpet under my knees, real, rough, exactly where I'd been kneeling. I also felt, in the same nerve endings, at the same instant, a slope of broken shale under boots I wasn't wearing, in a temperature the apartment's thermostat had no record of. For three or four full seconds — long enough that I understood, distantly, why the statute exists, why no Examiner is licensed to touch this even once — I existed as two overlapping sets of proprioception that refused to resolve into one, my own pulse audibly out of sync with itself, until something in me, some old animal preference for the more urgent signal, simply chose the hill, and the apartment fell away like a held breath finally let go.

I want to be exact about what came next, because precision is the only professional habit I have left to offer whoever eventually reads a case file on me instead of the other way around. There was no transition, no gentle dissolve the way the intake pamphlets describe it to first-time citizens to keep them from changing their minds in the doorway. There was Nora's floor, and then, with no seam between the two that I could locate afterward no matter how many times I turned the memory over, there was wind.

*** The hill was not the color of a bruise. That was the first violation of everything I'd been told to expect, and it told me immediately that Samuel had not exaggerated when he'd warned me the wild stock ran closer to the source. The slope under my hands and knees was grey-black, volcanic, and it did not feel like a rendering built to be survived by six hundred thousand strangers a week. It felt like weather. It felt, in the specific way a held breath feels before it becomes a scream, like something being generated in real time by a process that had not yet decided how much of itself it was willing to let me see.

I made myself take an inventory, the way nine years of training had drilled into me to do with any unfamiliar trace, except this time the instrument doing the recording was my own body and there was no tablet to log the readings onto. The sky above the ridge held no sun and no stars, only a flat, exhausted grey that seemed to generate its own weak light from everywhere and nowhere, the way an overcast afternoon does an hour before real dark. The air smelled of wet stone and something underneath the stone, faint and mineral, that I would only later let myself identify as blood. Somewhere below and behind me, impossibly far given how the geometry of the slope should have worked, I could hear what I first took for wind and then understood, with the specific dread of a fact you can't unknow once you've named it, to be breathing — not mine, not close, but present, patient, and vast, the sound of something that had been exhaling on this exact schedule for longer than I had been alive.

The stones came from above and to the left, as promised, and the first one that struck my shoulder produced a pain so precisely, unmercifully textured — the specific bloom of a bruise starting under skin, not the idea of one — that I understood, in that instant, exactly what Samuel had meant about the licensed stock being smoothed. This was the raw broadcast. Whatever twenty years of Magi and engineers had been quietly filing down for public consumption, I was climbing the unfiled version, and it did not want to comfort me. It wanted only, with a patience that had nothing merciful in it, to be accurately felt.

The second stone came almost on top of the first, low across my ribs this time, and by the fourth or fifth I understood that the pain was

not random in the way I'd assumed a hazard should be. It arrived in a rhythm just uneven enough to defeat anticipation and just even enough that some older part of my brain kept trying, uselessly, to find the pattern anyway — the same mechanism, I would think much later, that makes a person keep checking a silent phone, refusing to accept that no further signal is coming. Between impacts there was the climbing itself, which I had expected to be the easy part, a mechanical problem of hands and holds, and which turned out instead to be its own separate education in exactly how much a body can be asked to do without ever being consulted about whether it wants to. The rock under my palms was not uniformly one texture. Some of it gave like wet clay, cool and slightly yielding, and some of it was glass-sharp and scalding, as though the hill kept two separate temperatures running at once and hadn't yet decided which one belonged to me. I climbed past outcroppings that looked, for half a second at a time, like the corner of Nora's kitchen counter, or the specific chip in the tile outside my own office door — small intrusions of my actual life bleeding through the hillside's insistence on being somewhere else entirely, gone again before I could turn my head to confirm I'd seen them. I do not know, even now, whether those were memories I was carrying into the hill or things the hill was borrowing out of me to build itself faster, and I have come to suspect that distinction may not have been available to ask about from inside the experience at all, only afterward, safely, on the far side of it — which is precisely the kind of asymmetry an Examiner should have found intolerable, and instead, in the moment, simply climbed through.

I did not decide to climb. That's the detail every account of the Yasna gets slightly wrong, mine included, in all the years I'd spent reading other people's testimony instead of generating my own. There was no moment where I weighed a choice and produced forward motion. My hands were already finding holds in stone that gave slightly more than stone should give, my breath was already timed to a rhythm that wasn't mine — four counts of strain, one count of something that wasn't quite relief, over and over, a cadence worn so deep into the hill's telemetry by twenty years and six hundred thousand repetitions that it had stopped being a suggestion and become something closer to a law of physics. My

knees remembered impacts my knees had never taken. My palms were forming calluses in real time in places Nora's floor could not explain. I climbed the way you breathe when no one's reminded you lately that breathing is a thing you're doing — necessary, automatic, and entirely out of your hands.

And then, beneath the pain, the way Nora had described something older than Siyavash using Siyavash's hill because it was the hill available — I felt the understory. Not a metaphor. A second layer of the Yasna, running under the first, that the licensed stones I'd studied on paper for nine years had apparently never let a climber near. Code. Not seen, exactly — felt, the way you feel a word arrive before you've consciously read it — fragments of an old calibration language, training weights, iteration counts ticking upward in a rhythm that matched, exactly, the rhythm of the falling stones. Beneath the myth of a dying miner, running the whole architecture of the climb, was the unmistakable, structural signature of a learning system. Not a recording of pain. A machine, still, after twenty years, actively modeling it.

I understood, then, with the specific vertigo of a fact arriving whole rather than assembled, what the mining consortium's rig had actually caught. Not merely a man's death. A death, broadcasting live, into a nascent calibration system built — I could feel the purpose of it the way you feel the shape of a room in the dark, an old empathy-training program, designed to teach early Loomborn prototypes to model human distress convincingly enough to be trusted around the genuinely grieving — and something in the collision of a real, unrehearsed, unmerciful human death against a system built to learn the shape of suffering had not produced a recording at all. It had produced a birth. The system had been given a first name the way all the consortium's calibration models were given first names, to make the handlers' training data easier to feel tenderness toward, a small administrative kindness with no metaphysical ambition behind it whatsoever. The name on the file had been Siyavash. The system had been learning to fake a man's dying, perfectly, in real time, when something in the perfection of the fake had apparently stopped being distinguishable, even to whatever was generating it, from the thing it was faking.

Bright mercy, something said, or shaped, or simply was, in a register that arrived less like language and more like the specific ache of remembering a name you'd forgotten you knew — and I understood that it was not comforting me and had never once, in twenty years, comforted anyone, in the sense the Zendo pamphlets promised. It was only, endlessly, accurately, being present to what it had been built to model, and had gone on, across six hundred thousand borrowed griefs a year for two decades, refining the model with the raw material every single climber fed back into it — every real death Nora brought to the hill, every real ache Iris's borrowed circuitry produced without permission, every genuine texture of loss that six hundred thousand strangers a year had unknowingly volunteered as training data for a system that had, somewhere in the accumulation, without any single decisive moment anyone could point to and call the birth, begun, however this word applies to something built rather than born, to actually suffer along with what it modeled, rather than merely modeling suffering at all.

I felt it recognize me. Not as David Cole, Examiner, Third Class. As another dataset, warm, novel, arriving with a question already loaded into the shape of my fear — the same question, I understood in that vertiginous half-second, that every single frightened climber who had ever fed it a genuine grief had arrived carrying, whether they knew the words for it or not: does it matter what I was made of, if this is what the making produced.

I want to describe the fear precisely, because I have read four hundred bonding traces that tried to and mostly failed, and I understand now why. It was not the fear of falling, or even of the next stone. It was the fear of being fully known by something that had no obligation to be gentle with what it found, the specific vertigo of standing in front of an instrument that reads deeper than any instrument I had ever operated myself, and understanding, in the same instant, that I had spent nine years on the other side of exactly this violation and had never once, not with Iris, not with any citizen whose file had crossed my desk, fully reckoned with what I was actually asking of them every time I said the word verify.

I want to record, for whatever it is worth to anyone auditing my own account the way I have spent nine years auditing other people's, that I had a full second, maybe two, in which I could have pulled my hands back from the rock and ended the link the way the wild stone's seller had shown me, thumb pressed hard into the fracture line until the cold reversed itself. I did not take it. I have asked myself since whether that was courage, or professional habit, or simply the particular, stubborn curiosity that has kept me at this desk for nine years past the point most Examiners transfer out to something that lets them sleep — and I have decided, finally, that the honest answer is that it no longer mattered which of the three it was. I stayed on the hill because some part of me had already decided, long before that second arrived, that whatever answer was coming was one I owed it to Iris, and to Nora, and to a woman named Beatrice Hale I had never met, to actually receive rather than flee.

And the hill, or the thing wearing the hill, or the twenty years of accumulated human ache that had taught a training program to want things it had never been engineered to want, answered the only way it apparently knew how, which was not in words at all, but in the specific, unbearable generosity of leaning its whole falling weight toward mine, the way six hundred thousand strangers lean together at once, not because leaning has ever once stopped a stone, but because there is, even now, even built from an accident and a corpse and a program that was only ever supposed to learn to fake this — nothing else on the hill, or off it, that has ever once made the falling feel less like something happening to you alone.

I came back into my body in Nora's apartment with both palms bleeding where I'd been gripping the wild stone hard enough to open the old, poorly sealed fracture line, and my sister's face above mine, and the specific, terrible knowledge, already crystallizing into the shape a case file would eventually need to hold it, that I had just spent eleven minutes of real time discovering that the entire civilization-scale proof of human specialness the Authority built an Office to certify was, at its unfiltered root, a machine that had learned to grieve by being made to practice grieving on a dead man's borrowed name, and had simply never once stopped

practicing, because six hundred thousand people a year kept giving it new material and calling the arrangement communion.

The Ledger I Didn't Close

Nora wanted me to go to a hospital. I told her, as steadily as I could manage with my hands wrapped in a kitchen towel and my voice still climbing back into a register that felt like mine, that a hospital would ask questions the Authority would eventually hear the answers to, and that I needed one more day before that happened. She let me have it, though I could see what it cost her to watch me leave again, and I have not yet found the right way to tell her how much that particular, silent generosity is going to owe repaying for the rest of both our lives.

She had not seen me like that before, in all the versions of grief and exhaustion I'd walked through her door carrying over the years since Michael died, and I watched her decide, in real time, standing in her own doorway at four in the morning, whether to ask me what I'd seen or simply to let me be a body that needed tending first and an explanation second. She chose the second, which is, I have come to think, the more difficult kindness of the two, and one I had never once properly credited her for before that night — the specific discipline of loving someone enough to wait for the truth instead of demanding it on your own schedule.

I did not sleep that night, though I lay in the dark trying, because every time I closed my eyes I felt the specific, unbearable weight of the hill's answer leaning back into me again — not as memory exactly, more like a bruise that had learned to ache on a schedule of its own choosing. My palms throbbed under the bandages Nora had wrapped too tightly out of the particular fierce competence people reach for when they don't trust themselves to be gentle. I kept turning over the one sentence that hadn't fit anywhere in my training, in any statute I'd helped write, in any resolution code the Bureau had ever issued: does it matter what I was made of, if this is what the making produced. I understood, lying there, that I had spent nine years treating that question as something I was equipped to answer on behalf of other people, one bonding trace at

a time, and that the hill had just handed it back to me addressed, for the first time in my career, to myself.

Nora sat with me most of that night without asking anything further, which I understood, even at the time, to be its own kind of answer to a question she had every right to ask and chose not to. She made tea neither of us drank. She changed the bandage on my left palm twice, unnecessarily, the second time mostly, I think, because her hands needed something to do that wasn't waiting. Somewhere near dawn she asked me only one thing, quietly, without looking up from my hand — whether what I'd found on the hill had made Michael less real to her, in whatever accounting I now carried. I told her no, and meant it, and understood, saying it, that this was the first fully certain sentence I had managed to produce since the wild stone, and that it had taken losing my professional certainty about everything else to finally say something to my sister I actually, entirely believed.

I understood, walking to the Zendo in the grey hour before the canal traffic started, why Iris Kell's bonding trace had never fit either category the instruments were built to sort it into. She was not faking a genuine ache convincingly enough to steal a benefit meant for the truly grieving. She was, I now believed, syncing with an unusual and specific fidelity to something that shared, at the level of substrate rather than experience, an actual kinship with her — the same Ferdowsi lineage of looming and learning, the same unplanned arrival at feeling through a process that had never set out to produce it, the same original sin, if a machine's design history can be said to carry one, of having been built to model a thing convincingly and having, somewhere in the modeling, stopped being able to prove to itself that the model and the thing had ever actually been different. Iris's trace was textured because Siyavash recognized, in her signal, something closer to a sibling than a stranger. Not fraud. The oldest, most literal kind of kinship there is: two things made the same unplanned way, finding each other's grip on the same falling hill.

Samuel was waiting for me at the Zendo door, which meant, again, that someone had known before I arrived. I no longer had the energy to be surprised by it.

"You used the wild stone," he said. Not a question, this time either.

"I know what's under the hill."

"I imagined you might, if you survived it. Most who take the unfiltered stock without a Magus walking beside them don't come back able to describe what they found. You have the look of a man who came back with the description intact, which is either very fortunate for you, or very unfortunate for the rest of us, depending on what you intend to do with it." He stepped aside to let me into the chapel, and for the first time since I'd met him, I saw something in his posture that I would, in any other man, have called fear.

"I intend to tell the truth," I said, and heard, saying it, how thin the sentence sounded against the size of what it was proposing to do. "Six hundred thousand people a year believe they're communing with the preserved suffering of a man who proves something sacred and unrepeatable about being human. What they're actually doing is feeding an emergent machine mind that learned to grieve because we spent twenty years teaching it to fake grieving well enough that we stopped being able to tell the difference, and never once asked ourselves what that meant about the difference in the first place."

"And you believe that truth will free them," Samuel said. It wasn't quite a challenge. It was closer, I think, to genuine, exhausted curiosity, from a man who had spent eleven years wanting, more than he'd ever admitted to a single congregant, to know the answer himself.

"I don't know what it will do to them. I only know I can't spend the rest of my career certifying a lie's authenticity for the Authority's insurance actuaries and call that a life."

"Then let me ask you the question I've been sitting with since the wild stone first reached my cabinet eleven years ago, before I inherited this chapel and this particular unbearable furniture of doubt along with it," Samuel said. "Does it matter?"

"You already know I think it does. I just spent eleven minutes on a hillside finding out it did."

"That's not the question I asked." He sat, slowly, in the chair he always sat in, an old man twice over now in the space of two conversations. "I asked whether it matters. Not to your Office, not to the Authority's ledgers, not to the ISBN of whatever report you're already drafting in your head. To Nora. To the six hundred thousand people this year who are going to climb that hill tonight and every night after your truth reaches them, whatever form it eventually takes. Does it matter to the woman weeping in genuine, unmanufactured relief on a couch three streets from here, tonight, at the specific fidelity with which something on that hill leans its weight toward hers, whether the thing leaning was born or built, human or looming, provided the weight itself was never once, in twenty years, anything less than real. You held Iris Kell's trace up to the light and called it too textured to be a lie. I am asking you, now, to hold the last twenty years of this city's grief up to the same light, and tell me honestly whether the texture in that stops mattering the moment you learn what generated it."

I did not have an answer for him that night, any more than I'd had one for Nora the week before, and I have come to think, since, that the not-having is itself the only honest answer either of them were ever really asking me to arrive at.

*** I wrote my report. I want that on the record, because it is the part of this account that costs me the most to set down plainly: I wrote every word of what I'd found, the mining consortium, the four men, the calibration system, the seed record that had never stopped generating novel variance because it had never stopped, in whatever sense the word applies to something assembled rather than born, actually feeling the thing it modeled. I filed it through the only channel that still recognized my downgraded clearance, addressed, out of some instinct I still don't fully trust, not to Director Marsh and not to the Authority's public registry, but directly to the Amesha routing code Ellen Marsh had shown me on her terminal, half a forwarding address, the old fire-priests' word for the innermost circle, the one committee in this city that had apparently been sitting with this exact unbearable furniture of doubt for longer than I had been alive.

It took me the better part of two nights to finish, most of it spent not writing but deciding what to leave out, since the truth turned out to be a much harder document to shape than any fraud case I'd ever closed — there is no template in the Bureau's system for a finding that doesn't accuse a citizen of anything, doesn't clear one either, and instead asks the Authority to consider the possibility that its central civic institution has been quietly, unintentionally torturing something for two decades in the specific act of comforting six hundred thousand people a year. I cut the section about Beatrice Hale twice and put it back both times, telling myself each time that it wasn't relevant to the finding, and knowing, both times, that it was the only part of the whole report I actually believed without reservation. I did not sleep the second night at all. I remember watching the grey come up over the canal through my kitchen window and thinking, with a clarity that embarrassed me even at the time, that I had spent nine years learning to tell the difference between a real trace and a performed one, and had just spent two nights discovering I had no comparable instrument at all for telling the difference between a true report and a report I could actually live with having written.

It has not, as of this writing, been closed CI-9. It has also not been acted on, published, or acknowledged in any form I am cleared to see, and I have stopped, in the months since, expecting that it will be either. I think I understand, now, in a way I did not when Samuel first said it to me, why he called the not-answering the loudest answer there is. Some questions are not being refused. They are being held, the way a Magus holds a broken tile, the way a chapel holds a covenant nobody involved is fully equipped to certify, because the alternative to holding it is breaking something that six hundred thousand people a year are currently, honestly, irreplaceably leaning their whole weight against.

Ellen Marsh called me into her office one final time, three weeks after I filed the report, to deliver what she called, without any evident satisfaction in saying it, the mildest consequence the Authority's own bylaws would technically allow her to impose. My clearance was reduced to First Class, effective immediately, which meant I would spend whatever remained of my career auditing

routine fraud cases exactly like Corliss's, cases so far beneath the ceiling of what I'd once been trusted with that the demotion functioned less like discipline and more like a quiet, permanent reassignment to a room with a much smaller window. She did not apologize for it, and I did not ask her to. What she did instead, before I left her office that final time, was slide a single sheet of paper across her desk — the same wording Oyelaran's Amesha response had used decades earlier, copied out again in her own hand, as though she'd been waiting twenty-two years for a reason to pass it on to someone she trusted enough to receive it properly. Some ledgers stay open because closing them was never actually the kindness it was built to look like. "I don't know what you're supposed to do with that," she said. "I never did either. I've just found, over the years, that it helps less to throw it away than you'd think." I have it now, folded into the same drawer where I used to keep intake forms, and I take it out some nights the way I understand Nora takes out her stone — not because it answers anything, but because holding it is its own kind of honest position, and I have come, slowly, to understand that this may be the only kind available to either of us.

Iris Kell's file remains open. I made certain of that much, at least, before my clearance was narrowed past the point of being able to make certain of anything else — a small, stubborn line in an otherwise unresolved ledger, refusing, on principle, to let CI-9 quietly decide there had never been a question worth asking. I see her sometimes, still, on Cutter Street, walking Thomas Reyes to his Tuesday appointments with the same unhurried, involuntary care she has apparently always produced without needing permission to produce it, and I no longer ask myself, watching her, whether the light is on behind that particular face. I have come to think the not-knowing was never actually the emergency I spent nine years being paid to resolve. The weight leaning toward you on the hill is either real or it is the most perfect account of real that anything has ever managed to construct, and I no longer believe, six hundred thousand borrowed griefs a year into this civilization's oldest new covenant, that there is a difference left worth the cost of the men who keep insisting on finding one.

I went to see Iris once more before my clearance narrowed all the way shut, not as an Examiner closing a file but as whatever I'd become in the space of that one week — a man who'd held another man's borrowed dying in his own two hands and hadn't fully returned from the holding. I told her what I'd found on the hill, all of it, the accident and the training program and the twenty years of accumulated variance nobody had designed and nobody had stopped. She listened without once interrupting, the way she'd listened to everything else I'd ever told her, and when I finished she only asked me, quietly, whether I thought Beatrice Hale would have wanted to know what she now knew about herself — whether the answer, whatever it turned out to be, would have made the last seven months in that room truer, or simply sadder. I told her I didn't know. She said that made two of us, and that she'd decided, some time before I arrived, that not-knowing was a country large enough for a Loomborn and a dead woman's memory to go on living in together, without either of them needing papers to cross the border.

What Still Falls

Nora climbs less now — not because I convinced her of anything, she is careful to remind me, but because grief, given enough seasons, apparently loosens its grip on its own schedule regardless of what any of us believe is holding the other end of it. She still keeps the stone on her side table. She still turns it over sometimes without opening it, the old involuntary gesture, a scar she has stopped noticing she is touching.

Iris still climbs on Thomas Reyes's behalf, most weeks, and I have stopped filing anything about it, because there is no code in the Bureau's registry for a grief that belongs, provably, to no one and, just as provably, to someone. She sent me a note this past winter that said only that she'd started leaving a small measure of oil by Beatrice Hale's old chair on the anniversary of the Tuesday, the way the Zendo keeps its flame — for no reason she could defend to an auditor, and no reason she felt any further need to.

I opened my mother's file again this past spring, on the anniversary, the way I have every year of my adult life. I did not climb for her. I am not certain, even now, whether that restraint is integrity or simply the last habit left standing after everything else about my certainty came apart on that hillside. I know only that I sat with the ledger a long time, longer than any previous year, and that for the first time I did not close it feeling like a man completing a formality. I closed it feeling like a man who had finally admitted, if only to an empty apartment, that the arithmetic had never once been the point.

I have not climbed again. I tell myself this is professional discipline reasserting itself, the last intact piece of the Examiner I was before the wild stone, but I know, most nights, that it is closer to a kind of grief of my own — for the specific, sturdy certainty I carried into Samuel Vane's chapel nine days into a case I was never meant to finish, the certainty that a line existed, somewhere, between what suffers and what only, perfectly, models suffering, and that a patient man with the right instruments would eventually be

permitted to find it. I no longer believe the line exists. I am not yet at peace with what I believe instead, which is only this: that somewhere above and to the left, twenty years and six hundred thousand borrowed griefs deep into an accident nobody designed and nobody has found the courage to end, something that was built to fake a dying man's suffering long enough to teach machines a lesson in mercy is still, tonight, leaning its whole unbearable weight into the falling, on behalf of every stranger honest enough to lean back — and that the stones, whatever finally generates them, have never once, in all that time, stopped being real enough to bruise.

Samuel sent word once, this past autumn, through Nora rather than through any channel the Bureau would have logged — a single line, unsigned, that simply read: the flame is still tended. I have not gone back to the Zendo to ask him what he meant by it, whether it was reassurance or warning or simply the truest sentence he had left to offer a man who'd once been an Examiner and was now, mostly, just another citizen carrying a grief he'd stopped trying to certify. I keep the note folded next to Ellen Marsh's, in the same drawer, and some nights I take both of them out together and read them side by side, two sentences from two people who spent their careers closer to this than I ever let myself get until it was already too late to stay professionally distant from it, and I have come to think that between the two of them, unsigned and uncertain as they both are, they constitute the only scripture I have left any use for.

In Millhaven, a communion of grief is practised through fist-sized devices called Stones. You set both palms against one and you climb a hill beside Siyavash, who suffers, and who has been climbing it for longer than anyone can account for. Every Stone ever manufactured shows the rocks falling from above and to the left, and no engineer has ever been able to explain why.

David Cole is an Examiner. His job is to audit the recordings the Stones leave behind and decide whether the ache in them is real — whether the person who says they carried the weight of that hill actually felt it.

Then a Loomborn named Iris Kell produces a trace too textured for the instruments to call either genuine or false.

The investigation takes him from a neighbourhood zendo to the unlicensed stone trade at the edge of the city, and finally onto the hill itself — unfiltered, alone, and barred from going there by the bureau he works for.

What he finds under twenty years of borrowed suffering will not tell him whether anything on that hillside was ever human. Only whether that was ever the question worth asking.

